Workflow Mapping I: The Current State

Instructor guide · Day 2 · Session 3

Why map before you automate, SIPOC, swimlanes, touch and wait time, pain-point tags, mapping interviews

Session at a glance

Day / session	Day 2 · Session 3 · 120 minutes
Lead instructors	Mousa AL-Akhras, Mohammed Abdelmajeed
Online module	https://albanna-tutorials.com/ai-administrator/03_workflow_mapping_current_state.html
Deck	Day2_S3_Mapping_Current_State.pptx, 45 slides, speaker notes included

Learning objectives

- Explain why an unmapped process cannot be safely automated.
- Produce a SIPOC summary, with a trigger and an end state, for a real task.
- Draw a swimlane diagram that shows every actor, step, decision, hand-off and wait.
- Write touch time and wait time on every step and say which kind of fix each one needs.
- Tag pain points with the course vocabulary (REKEY, WAIT, READ, DRAFT, CHASE, RUBBER, JUDGE).
- Run a short mapping interview with a colleague without leading them.

Run of show

Minutes	Block	Focus
5 to 15	1. Why map before you automate	Automation makes a process rigid. Look at it before you freeze it.
15 to 30	2. Start wide: the SIPOC	Fix the boundaries before you draw a single step
30 to 55	3. The swimlane diagram	One lane per actor. Every lane crossing is a hand-off.
55 to 65	Break	10 minutes
65 to 80	4. Tagging pain points	One vocabulary for every map, so maps can be compared
80 to 90	5. Mapping with colleagues	You rarely know the whole process

90 to 105	Practical: a live map reviewer	Send your step list to an AI reviewer from your phone. Nothing to install.
105 to 115	Kahoot: knowledge check	20 questions, 20 seconds each. Phones out.
115 to 120	Practical lab: map your own task	Steps shown now, finish before Session 4

The welcome, objectives and run-of-show slides take the first minutes before Section 1. The break is planned at the midpoint (see the run-of-show slide in the deck). Cuts if running behind are listed under Troubleshooting.

Materials checklist

- Projector or screen share; this deck (Day2_S3_Mapping_Current_State.pptx) with speaker notes open.
- draw.io open in a browser tab (app.diagrams.net) or the desktop app, with Day2_S3_Swimlane_Template.drawio loaded for the live demo, and Day2_S3_Leave_Request_Example.drawio as the finished answer.
- Practical worksheet (Day2_S3_Practical_Map_Reviewer.pdf) shared in the chat at minute 90; lab handout (Day2_S3_Lab_Handout.pdf) at minute 115.
- The map reviewer bot running on the course server (Day2_S3_Map_Reviewer_Setup_Guide.pdf); phone with Telegram for a test message; the bot QR on the Join slide.
- Fallback: the leave-request step list and the expected bot answer printed in the setup guide, in case Wi-Fi, Telegram or the model provider fails.
- Kahoot imported from Day2_S3_Kahoot.xlsx and ready to launch (PIN on screen at minute 105); answer key Day2_S3_Kahoot_Answer_Key.pdf. The written Quiz bank (Day2_S3_Quiz_Bank.pdf) stays available for homework or revision.
- Participants: their M1 task inventory and chosen course task from Day 1, a draw.io account or the desktop app, and an AI assistant. Nothing to install if they use the browser version.

Before the session

- Read the live module once (link above); the slides follow its five sections in order.
- Practise the live demo twice: build the leave-request swimlane in draw.io from the template in under 12 minutes. The finished file is the answer key.
- The day before: start the map reviewer (see the setup guide), message the bot from your phone, paste the leave-request step list and check that it finds the missing department-head approval and the missing escalation.
- Agree with the co-instructor who plays the colleague in the interview role-play (minute 85) and rehearse the one leading question you will catch.
- Remind participants to bring their M1 task inventory: the lab maps the task they chose on Day 1.

Live demo and practical (minutes 35 to 55, and 90 to 105)

1. Minute 35: open Day2_S3_Swimlane_Template.drawio. Rename the lanes to Employee, Line manager, HR coordinator, HR portal, Team spreadsheet. Say out loud why systems get lanes.

2. Minute 38: build the leave-request map left to right, narrating each shape: trigger (email), steps, the decision diamond with labelled Yes and No exits.
3. Minute 46: add touch time inside each step and the wait on each arrow. Add the totals: 25 minutes of touch, about 4 days elapsed.
4. Minute 50: count the hand-offs together (eight). Compare with Day2_S3_Leave_Request_Example.drawio and show the 'touch versus wait' slide.
5. Minute 88: check the map reviewer is running and send one test message. Minute 90: Join slide; participants scan the QR and press Start.
6. Minute 93: participants paste the leave-request steps from the worksheet, then a short list from their own task. Minute 100: debrief, one finding per category.
7. Optional filler if the bot cannot run: paste the same step list into any AI assistant with the review prompt from lab step 7 and compare the answer with the 'What the reviewer should find' slide.

Slide-by-slide talking points

Slide numbers match the deck. Quiz questions occupy two slides each (question, then answer).

1. Workflow Mapping I: The Current State · **Title**
Welcome back. One sentence promise: by the end of these two hours everyone has a method to draw the process they chose on Day 1 exactly as it runs today, with numbers and named pain points, and has had the map checked by a live AI reviewer. Still no code; the first automation is built on Day 3.

2. Where this session sits · **Bullets**
Link back to Day 1: participants left with a task inventory and one chosen course task. Today they map that task. The leave policy from Session 2 is reused on purpose: everyone already knows the official rules, so the gap between the rules and what really happens is easy to see.

3. What you will be able to do after this session · **Bullets**
Read quickly. The deliverable is the current-state map of their own course task; it is the input to Session 4 and to everything built on Day 3. Mention the Kahoot so phones are ready.

4. Run of show (120 minutes) · **Table**
Ten seconds on screen. The break is earlier than on Day 1 because the demo is long.

5. 1. Why map before you automate · **Section** · **minute 5**
Ten minutes. The point to land: automation freezes whatever you show it, so look first.

6. The most common automation failure is not technical · **Callout**
Ask: who has seen a new system go live and then everyone kept their old spreadsheet anyway? Hands up. That spreadsheet is the real process. Automation freezes what you show it; if you never looked, you freeze the workarounds too, or you break them.

7. The process people describe, and the one that runs · **Figure** · **figure: d2s3_freeze**
Walk the two rows. Top: what the leave policy says (Session 2's document). Bottom: what actually happens. The orange boxes are steps nobody mentioned. Automating the top row would either break the bottom row or leave people doing both. Every orange box is a finding from mapping, not from a tool.

8. Mapping is cheap, and often fixes a third of the problem · **Bullets**
Make the economics plain: an automation project costs weeks; a map costs hours. The map is also what the future-state design in Session 4 and the n8n build on Day 3 are drawn from.

9. The rule · Callout
This is the sentence to remember. Steps a stranger cannot do from the description are usually JUDGE steps or steps with hidden knowledge. Both must be found before automating.

10. 2. Start wide: the SIPOC · Section · minute 15
Fifteen minutes including the room exercise. Boundaries before boxes.

11. SIPOC: five questions · Table
SIPOC is a one-line summary that stops you mapping the wrong thing. Fill it top to bottom or start from P; both work. The P column is deliberately coarse: five to seven boxes. The detail comes in the swimlane.

12. The leave-request SIPOC · Figure · figure: d2s3_sipoc
Point at the trigger line. Today the trigger is an email; officially it is a portal submission. That mismatch is itself a finding. Automation tools need something to listen for: an email arriving, a form submitted, a date. End state: how do you know it is finished? If nobody can say, the process never really ends.

13. Room exercise (5 minutes): SIPOC for ordering office supplies · Steps
Expect two different triggers ('stock runs low' versus 'someone emails the office manager'). Good: that is the point of writing the trigger down. Model answer: Suppliers = staff, office manager, vendor; Inputs = request, budget, catalogue; Process = request, check budget, approve, order, receive, distribute; Outputs = delivered items, invoice; Customers = staff, finance. Trigger: a request or a low-stock check. End: items delivered and invoice matched.

14. 3. The swimlane diagram · Section · minute 30
Twenty-five minutes, most of it the live draw.io demo. Have the template open before you click.

15. What a swimlane shows · Bullets
The swimlane is older than any software: it comes from Rummler and Brache's cross-functional process maps (references). BPMN calls them pools and lanes. We use the plain version.

16. Four shapes are enough · Figure · figure: d2s3_notation
One action per box. If a decision has more than two exits it is usually two decisions. Waits are written on the arrows, and they are usually longer than the work.

17. Live demo: build the leave-request map in draw.io · Callout
About 15 minutes. Follow the demo steps in the instructor guide. Narrate every choice: why the spreadsheet gets a lane, why the decision has two labelled exits, where the email sits. Ask the room for the next step before you draw it. If you run short of time, open the finished file and walk it instead.

18. The current state, as it really runs · Figure · figure: d2s3_swimlane
Compare with the demo. Count the hand-offs together: eight arrows cross lanes. Point at the dashed lookups (the manager's private sheet, the HR record) and at the decision's No exit. Ask: what is missing? Hold the answer: the bot will find it in the practical (department-head approval at quarter end, escalation after three days).

19. Two numbers on every step · Two columns
This distinction decides what you automate. People feel slow; usually the process is slow because it queues. In lean terms, process time versus lead time (Rother and Shook in the references).

20. 25 minutes of work, four days of waiting · Figure · figure: d2s3_touch_wait
Read the totals from the map: 25 minutes of touch time, about 4 working days elapsed, six queues. Ask: if an AI step cut the manager's reading time from 6 minutes to 1, how much faster is the process? Almost not at all. The queues are the target, and queues are fixed by routing and reminders, not by AI.

21. Map what happens, not what should · Callout
The leave policy even says managers must not keep separate spreadsheets. They do. That is not a reason to leave it off the map; it is the reason to put it on.

22. Break · **Section · minute 55**
Ten minutes. Restart at minute 65 sharp; the tags section is short and the practical cannot slip.

23. 4. Tagging pain points · **Section · minute 65**
Fifteen minutes. Seven tags, applied to the map everyone has just seen built.

24. Seven tags · **Figure · figure: d2s3_tags**
Go row by row with an example from the room for each. The fix column previews Session 4 and Day 3. Spend time on RUBBER: approvals that are always given without reading. They feel like control; they are only delay.

25. The leave-request map, tagged · **Figure · figure: d2s3_tagged**
Ask the room to justify three tags. Why is HR's portal approval RUBBER? Because the manager already decided and HR approves every request. Why is re-entering in the portal REKEY? Because the request already exists in the email. Where is the JUDGE? The manager's decision on clashes: a real decision about the team.

26. JUDGE is a tag, not a problem · **Callout**
This closes the fear many participants have: mapping is not a plan to remove them. It is how the decisions that need them get named and protected.

27. 5. Mapping with colleagues · **Section · minute 80**
Ten minutes including the three-minute role-play.

28. Ask this, not that · **Two columns**
The last real case contains the exceptions; a general description leaves them out. Ask 'what happens if' at every decision: if the manager is on leave, if the balance is negative, if the form is incomplete.

29. Role-play (3 minutes) · **Steps**
Rehearsed beforehand. The planted leading question: 'You always check the balance in the portal, right?' The HR coordinator answers 'Yes' and only later admits managers email her for balances because they have no portal access. That is the CHASE step on the map. Close with the rules on the next slide.

30. Five rules for an honest interview · **Bullets**
These come straight from the module. The last rule is the one people skip; the lab makes it a required step.

31. Practical: a live map reviewer · **Section · minute 90**
Check the reviewer is running (setup guide). Share the worksheet PDF in the chat. Same server as the Day 1 agent, a different job: it only reviews maps.

32. Meet the map reviewer · **Bullets**
One minute. Link to Day 1: same four parts (model, tools, memory, instructions), but here tools and memory are deliberately switched off. A narrow job makes a reliable assistant.

33. Join the map reviewer · **Join (QR)**
Three minutes. Pair anyone without Telegram with a neighbour.

34. Three tasks (10 minutes) · **Steps**
Walk the room. In Task 1 most people will get the department-head approval at quarter end and the missing escalation after three working days; if not, show the next slide. Task 3 should be politely declined.

35. What the reviewer should find in the example · **Two columns**
Five minutes of debrief. Ask for one finding per category from the room. In testing (4 October 2026) the bot found the notice-period, probation and department-head gaps and HR's missing decline path, but missed the three-day escalation. Ask the room what it missed: the answer is in the leave policy, Section 3. That is how you verify an AI reviewer: compare it with a source you trust.

36. The reviewer is a colleague, not an authority · Callout
This is the same lesson as Session 2's trap questions: verify against the source. It also keeps the lab honest: the bot review is step 7, the colleague confirmation is step 8.

37. Kahoot: knowledge check · Section · minute 105
Launch the Kahoot now; ten minutes.

38. Join the Kahoot · Two columns
Import Day2_S3_Kahoot.xlsx into Kahoot beforehand (Create, then Import spreadsheet). Launch in Classic mode and show the PIN on this slide. Ten minutes covers most of the 20 questions; assign the rest as a challenge. The answer key with rationales is Day2_S3_Kahoot_Answer_Key.pdf.

39. Practical lab: map your own task · Section · minute 115
Five minutes to show the lab; the work itself is done before Session 4.

40. Lab steps · Steps
Share the handout and the template in the chat. Walk the steps in four minutes. The common mistakes: no systems lanes, no wait times, mapping the official version. The deliverable is saved as M3-current-state.

41. Step 7: the review prompt (for any assistant) · Prompt text
The same instructions the reviewer bot runs on, so participants without Telegram get the same result in any assistant. Point at the constraint 'Do not suggest automation yet': that is Session 4.

42. Deliverable · Callout
Be explicit that Session 4 starts from this file. Without it there is nothing to redesign.

43. Key takeaways · Bullets
Read the five. Then preview Session 4: the same map, redesigned. Remove the RUBBER step, route the waits, add AI only where READ and DRAFT appear, and keep the JUDGE step with a better summary.

44. Latest reading: map before you automate (2026) · Latest articles
Optional two minutes or self-study. Instructors may swap in newer pieces; keep the pattern of source, date and a one-line takeaway tied to the session.

45. References · References
Leave on screen during questions. All figures were drawn for this course; the leave process and AI Caravan Ltd. are fictional.

Practical setup summary (map reviewer on Telegram)

- Runs on the same course droplet as Day 1 (AI-Caravan, 165.245.213.121), as a second Hermes profile called mapreview next to the default bot and the policy bot, served by the same gateway.
- Persona in ~/.hermes/profiles/mapreview/SOUL.md: reviews a list of process steps and answers in a fixed shape (missing steps, decisions without a 'no' path, three riskiest hand-offs, suggested pain-point tags). It never proposes automation and declines anything else.
- No tools and no memory: platform_toolsets.telegram is empty and memory is off, so it only reasons over what participants paste.
- Its own Telegram bot (created in BotFather by the course author) with the token in the profile's .env on the server only, never in this repository.
- After the session: hermes gateway stop and delete the profile's sessions folder. The server and bots stay for the whole course.

Full step-by-step instructions, persona text and fallbacks: **Day2_S3_Map_Reviewer_Setup_Guide.pdf** (in this package).

Troubleshooting and cuts

If	Then
Participants forgot their Day 1 task inventory	Let them map the leave-request process for the lab and switch to their own task as homework. The skills are the same.
'My process has no clear trigger'	Ask what happened just before they started the last one: an email, a date, a form, a phone call. If there is truly no trigger, it is not yet a process; note it as a finding.
draw.io is blocked on the corporate laptop	Use paper and sticky notes with one row per actor, then photograph it. Miro, Lucidchart or PowerPoint SmartArt also work; the deliverable is the map, not the tool.
Participants map the official procedure instead of what happens	Point at the 'Map what happens' slide and ask, 'When did you last follow it exactly?' The private team spreadsheet in the example is a deliberate workaround to discuss.
The map reviewer bot suggests automation or goes off topic	Its instructions forbid both; if it slips, say so, it is the same guard failure as Day 1 Task 4, and note it for Day 6. Use the fallback answer slide.
Wi-Fi, Telegram or the model provider fails during the practical	Run the optional filler in any assistant, or walk through the 'What the reviewer should find' slide as a whole-room exercise. Keep the timing.
Running behind at the break	Shorten the SIPOC room exercise to three minutes and cut the notation slide (the demo shows the shapes anyway). Do not cut the live demo, the practical or the lab kickoff.

Latest articles used on the slides

- **Stop Automating Old Processes. Design New Ones Instead.**. Harvard Business Review, by Masha Shunko and Serguei Netessine, 14 September 2026. hbr.org/2026/09/stop-automating-old-processes-design-new-ones-instead
  Companies doubling AI spend still miss returns because they automate individual tasks instead of redesigning the end-to-end workflow. Today's map is the end-to-end view; Session 4 is the redesign.
- **Process Intelligence Landscape 2026: Mining, Orchestration, and the Agentic AI Shift**. Kai Waehner, 22 July 2026. kai-waehner.de/blog/2026/07/22/process-intelligence-landscape-2026-mining-orchestration-and-the-agentic-ai-shift
  Process mining reconstructs how work really runs from system logs, and 'most of the value lands before an agent enters the picture'. A hand-drawn current-state map is the manual version of the same idea.
- **2026 Work Trend Index: Agents, Human Agency, and the Opportunity for Every Organization**. Microsoft WorkLab, 5 May 2026. microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/agents-human-agency-and-the-opportunity-for-every-organization
  Defining the desired outcome and designing how work flows across people and AI must come before handing

work to agents; organisational factors matter more than individual skill. The JUDGE tag is where that design starts.

References

1. Al-Banna, A. (2026). AI Administrator, Module 3: Workflow Mapping I, The Current State. albanna-tutorials.com/ai-administrator/03_workflow_mapping_current_state.html
2. Rummler, G. A. and Brache, A. P. (2012). Improving Performance: How to Manage the White Space on the Organization Chart, 3rd ed. Jossey-Bass (origin of the swimlane 'process map' with cross-functional lanes)
3. George, M. L., Rowlands, D., Price, M. and Maxey, J. (2005). The Lean Six Sigma Pocket Toolbook. McGraw-Hill (SIPOC, value-stream and process-mapping tools)
4. Rother, M. and Shook, J. (2003). Learning to See: Value Stream Mapping to Add Value and Eliminate Muda. Lean Enterprise Institute (process time versus lead time)
5. Object Management Group (2013). Business Process Model and Notation (BPMN) 2.0.2. omg.org/spec/BPMN (the formal notation behind pools and lanes)
6. draw.io / diagrams.net documentation: swimlanes and containers. drawio.com/doc
7. Hermes Agent documentation and source (Nous Research, MIT licence). hermes-agent.nousresearch.com/docs · github.com/NousResearch/hermes-agent
8. IEEE CS Region 8 AI Caravan (2026). AI Administrator Track Curriculum. aicaravan.org

Figure: AI Administrator course material (A. Al-Banna, 2026). All figures in this deck were drawn for the course (tools/make_day2_figures.py); the running example is the fictional AI Caravan Ltd. leave process.